

A TEACHING FROM THE BRANCH OF RIGHTEOUSNESS

Still on Milk

The Marks of Carnality in 1 Corinthians

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Introduction

Beyond the Veil rests on a single diagnostic question, the one Paul puts to the church at Corinth: are you living on milk, or have you gone on to solid food? Hebrews gives us the vocabulary for that question — the word of righteousness, the elementary principles, the trained senses that discern good from evil (Hebrews 5:12–14). But it is Paul’s letter to the Corinthians that gives us the clinical picture. He does not simply define milk. He shows it to us, walking around in a congregation that was, by every visible measure, thriving.

That detail matters more than it first appears. Corinth was not a congregation lacking anything. Paul had already told them so: they were “enriched in every thing, in all utterance, and in all knowledge” (1 Corinthians 1:5), and they came behind “in no gift” (1:7). This was not an uninformed church. It was an articulate, gifted, doctrinally fluent church — and Paul still calls them babes. That is the first and most uncomfortable clue Paul gives us about what milk actually is: it is not the absence of knowledge. It is possible to know a great deal and still be on milk.

The Anchor Text

1 CORINTHIANS 3:1–3 (KJV)

“And I, brethren, could not speak unto you as unto spiritual, but as unto carnal, even as unto babes in Christ. I have fed you with milk, and not with meat: for hitherto ye were not able to bear it, neither yet now are ye able. For ye are yet carnal: for whereas there is among you envying, and strife, and divisions, are ye not carnal, and walk as men?”

Read slowly, this short passage hands us three distinct clues — not abstract theological markers, but named, visible behaviours. Paul does not say, “you are carnal because your doctrine is immature.” He says: I can see it, because of what is *among you*.

Three Clues, Named in the Text

Ye are yet carnal

The word Paul uses, *sarkikos*, does not describe someone without the Spirit. These were believers — “babes in Christ,” he calls them, not strangers to Christ. Carnality here is not a question of standing but of government: whose pattern is currently running your reactions? The flesh can still be the operating system of a truly regenerate person. Milk-drinking is not unbelief. It is belief that has not yet displaced the flesh’s older habits of self-protection, self-promotion, and self-interest.

Envy, strife, and divisions

This is Paul's actual evidence, and it is worth noticing how relational it is. He does not point to a doctrinal error. He points to *envy* — a heart that cannot rejoice at another's portion without comparing its own. He points to *strife* — the appetite for contention, the need to win the exchange. He points to *divisions* — people sorting themselves into camps by loyalty to a personality rather than by union with Christ (this is exactly what chapter 1 already exposed: "I am of Paul; and I of Apollos; and I of Cephas", 1:12). Milk, by this clue, is truth that has been received into the mind but has not yet reordered how a person relates to the people around them.

"Walk as men"

The phrase is, more literally, *kata anthropon* — according to man, by the ordinary pattern of fallen human relating. This is the summary clue that gathers up the other two: a carnal believer is recognisable not because they cannot quote Scripture, but because, under pressure, they default to the same instincts as anyone with no faith at all — compare, defend, retaliate, withdraw, take sides. The measure of spiritual food, on this reading, is never how much a person knows. It is whether, in the moment envy or strife presents itself, something other than the flesh now answers first.

A Working Definition of Milk

Put the two letters together and a definition emerges that is sharper than "milk means basic doctrine." Hebrews tells us milk-drinkers are "unskilful in the word of righteousness" (5:13) — not ignorant of it, but untrained in living by it. Corinthians shows us exactly what that lack of skill looks like on the ground: envy instead of contentment, strife instead of peace, faction instead of unity. Taken together:

Milk is truth that has not yet become character. It is doctrine a person can recite, defend, and even teach, that has not yet been worked, through repeated practice, into the instinctive shape of their responses. Solid food, by contrast, is truth that has been metabolised — truth that has, over time and through use, retrained the reflexes.

What Solid Food Trains

HEBREWS 5:14 (KJV)

"But strong meat belongeth to them that are of full age, even those who by reason of use have their senses exercised to discern both good and evil."

Notice the phrase “by reason of use.” Solid food is not a higher tier of information. It is the fruit of repeated, deliberate practice — the senses trained the way a hand is trained by labour. This is why Beyond the Veil treats contemplative practice, self-examination, and the quiet discipline of watching one’s own thoughts as more than devotional preference. It is the actual gymnasium in which milk becomes meat: the place where envy is caught in the moment it rises, named honestly before God, and refused, until refusing it becomes less effort than yielding to it once was.

For Reflection

1. Where, this week, did envy, strife, or a need to take sides rise in you before you had time to choose a better response? What did that reveal about which pattern is currently trained — flesh, or Spirit?
 2. Is there an area of your life where you can recite the truth accurately but have not yet let it reorder how you treat a specific person?
 3. Paul’s Corinthians were gifted and articulate, yet still carnal. Where might knowledge be substituting, in your own walk, for the slower work of trained character?
 4. What single practice — prayer, silence, honest confession — could become your gymnasium this season, the place where a truth you already know starts becoming a reflex you live by?
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A Closing Word

Milk is not a verdict on your worth, and solid food is not a trophy for the spiritually advanced. It is simply a measure of how far truth has travelled — from the mind, into the reflexes, into the place where envy rises and strife presents its opening and something other than the flesh now answers first. The Corinthians did not need more information. They needed the information they already had to keep walking, quietly, ordinary day by ordinary day, until it became the shape of how they related to one another.

“Therefore leaving the principles of the doctrine of Christ, let us go on unto perfection” (Hebrews 6:1).

Be trained enough that truth no longer waits to become you.